Three Types of Mandarin Double-object Constructions

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Three Types of Double-object Constructions

Mandarin Chinese permits three types of double-object constructions, all showing superficially similar retained-object structures under passivization. However, empirical evidence reveals sharp asymmetries in their extraction patterns.

➢ Canonical double-object construction ($V_{ditran.}$):

(1) *a. Canonical double-object construction*

wo tongzhi-le Zhangsan zhe-jian shi
1SG inform-PRF John this-CL matter
'I informed John about this matter.'

b. Direct object (Theme) as the subject under Passive

zhe-jian shi bei (wo) tongzhi-le Zhangsan
this-CL matter BEI (1SG) inform-PRF John
'This matter was informed John about (by me).'

c. Indirect object (Goal) as the subject under Passive

Zhangsan bei (wo) tongzhi-le zhe-jian shi
John BEI (1SG) inform-PRF this-CL matter
'John was informed about this matter (by me).'

◆ Theme extraction ✅ Goal extraction ✅

◆ Semantically, possession transfer of Theme to Goal

➢ Affectee-Theme double-object construction (Vt.):

(2) *a. Affective double-object construction*

wo tou-le Lisi yi-ge qianbao
1SG steal-PRF Lee one-CL purse
'I stole a purse from Lee.'

b. Direct object (Theme) as the subject under Passive

* yi-ge qianbao bei (wo) tou-le Lisi
one-CL purse BEI (1SG) steal-PRF Lee
Int. 'A purse was stolen from Lee (by me).'

c. Indirect object (Affectee) as the subject under Passive

Lisi bei (wo) tou-le yi-ge qianbao
Lee BEI (1SG) steal-PRF one-CL purse
'Lee was stolen a purse (by me).'

◆ Theme extraction ❌ Affectee extraction ✅

◆ Semantically, possession transfer of Theme from Affectee

➢ Canonical double-object construction (Vt.):

(3) *a. Instrument double-object construction*

wo chi-le da-wan niurou mian
1SG eat-PRF big-bowl beef noodle
'I ate beef noodle with a big bowl.'

b. Direct object (Theme) as the subject under Passive

niu-rou mian bei (wo) chi-le da-wan
beef noodle BEI (1SG) eat-PRF big-bowl
'The beef noodle was eaten with a big bowl (by me).'

c. Indirect object (Instrument) as the subject under Passive

da-wan bei (wo) chi-le niu-rou mian
big-bowl BEI (1SG) eat-PRF beef noodle
'With the big bowl, the beef noodle was eaten (by me).'

◆ Theme extraction ✅ Instrument extraction ✅

◆ No semantic relation between Instrument and Theme

Proposed Analysis

For ditransitive verbs, the oblique object is lexically selected by V and introduced directly in its specifier. In contrast, monotransitive verbs inherently select only Agent and Theme; an oblique object requires an ApplP (phase), which is contextually licensed. The VP/ApplP combine with Voice via Event Identification.

➢ Canonical double-object construction ($V_{ditran.}$):

(6a=1b) *Direct object (Theme) extracted*

$[_{TP}\ Subj_{[\Phi][A']}\ T_{[\Phi]}\ [_{PassP}\ t\ Pass_{[\Phi+A']}\ [_{vP}\ (Ag.)\ [_{v'}\ v+V\ [_{VP}\ Goal\ [_{V'}\ V\ Theme_{[\Phi][A']}]]]]]]$

(6b=1c) *Indirect object (Goal) extracted*

$[_{TP}\ Subj_{[\Phi][A']}\ T_{[\Phi]}\ [_{PassP}\ t\ Pass_{[\Phi+A']}\ [_{vP}\ (Ag.)\ [_{v'}\ v+V\ [_{VP}\ Goal_{[\Phi][A']}\ [_{V'}\ V\ Theme]]]]]]$

c. $V_{<e,<e,<s,t>>>}$: λx.λy.λe.V(e, x, y)

d. $VP_{<s,t>}$: λe.V(e, NP_{Theme}, NP_{Goal})

e. $Voice_{<e,<s,t>>}$: λx.λe.AGENT(e, x)

f. $Voice'_{<e,<s,t>>}$: λx.λe.V(e, NP_{Theme}, NP_{Goal}) & AGENT(e, x)

g. Pass: $\lambda f_{<e<s,t>>}$.λe.(∃x:)f(x, e)

➢ Affectee-Theme double-object construction (Vt.+ Low-Appl):

(7a.1=2b) *Direct object (Theme) extracted*

$[_{TP}\ Subj_{[\Phi][A']}T_{[\Phi]}[_{PassP}\ t\ Pass_{[\Phi+A']}[_{vP}\ (Ag.)\ [_{v'}\ v+V[_{VP}\ V\ [_{ApplP}\ t\ Aff.[_{Appl'}\ Appl_{[\Phi+A']}Th._{[\Phi][A']}]]]]]]]$

Violate Comp-Spec Anti-locality! *(Abels 2003, 2012)*

◆ This analysis is further supported across three distinct movement types——

- Mixed A/A'-movement (see 2b)
- A-movement: IP-internal Topicalisation

(7a.2) * wo qianbao tou-le Lisi
1SG purse steal-PRF Lee
Int.: 'I, the purse, have stolen from Lee.'

- A'-movement: IP-external Topicalisation

(7a.3) * qianbao, wo tou-le Lisi
purse 1SG steal-PRF Lee
Int.: 'The purse, I have stolen from Lee.'

(7b=2c) *Indirect object (Affectee) extracted*

$[_{TP}\ Subj_{[\Phi][A']}T_{[\Phi]}\ [_{PassP}\ t\ Pass_{[\Phi+A']}\ [_{vP}\ (Ag.)[_{v'}\ v+V\ [_{VP}\ V\ [_{ApplP}\ Aff._{[\Phi][A']}[_{Appl'}\ Appl_{[\Phi+A']}\ Th.]]]]]]]$

c. $Low\text{-}Appl_{<e,<e,<<e,<s,t>>,<s,t>>>>}$: λx.λy.$\lambda f_{<e,<s,t>>}$.λe.f(e, x)&to-the-possession(x, y)

d. $Low\text{-}AppP_{<<e,<s,t>>,<s,t>>}$: $\lambda f_{<e,<s,t>>}$.λe.f(e, $NP_{The.}$)&to-the-possession($NP_{The.}$, $NP_{Aff.}$)

e. $V_{<e,<s,t>>}$: λx.λe.V(e, x)

f. $VP_{<s,t>}$: λe.V(e, NP_{Theme})&to-the-possession(NP_{Theme}, $NP_{Affectee}$)

➢ Canonical double-object construction (High Appl + Vt.):

(8a=3b) *Direct object (Theme) extracted*

$[_{TP}\ Subj_{[\Phi][A']}\ T_{[\Phi]}\ [_{PassP}\ t\ Pass_{[\Phi+A']}\ [vP\ (Ag.)\ [_{v'}\ v+V\ [_{ApplP}\ t\ Instru.\ [_{VP}\ V\ Theme_{[\Phi][A']}]]]]]]$

(8b=3c) *Indirect object (Goal) extracted*

$[_{TP}\ Subj_{[\Phi][A']}\ T_{[\Phi]}\ [_{PassP}\ t\ Pass_{[\Phi+A']}\ [_{vP}\ (Ag.)\ [_{v'}\ v+V\ [_{ApplP}\ Instru._{[\Phi][A']}\ [_{VP}\ V\ Theme]]]]]]$

c.$V_{<e,<s,t>>}$: λx.λe.V(e, x)

d.$VP_{<s,t>}$: λe.V(e, NP_{Theme})

e.$High\text{-}Appl_{<e,<s,t>>}$: λy.λe.$Appl_{Instr.}$(e,y)

f.$High\text{-}ApplP_{<s,t>}$: λe.V(e, NP_{Theme}) & $Appl_{Instr.}$(e, $NP_{Instr.}$)

Theoretical Building Blocks

➢ Chen (2023) on Mandarin Passives: Mixed A/A'-Movement

The passive head *Bei* probes with both φ- and A'-features, triggering composite A/A'-movement of a DP (either IO or DO). Following Kratzer (1996)&Bruening (2013): Pass, as phase head, selects VoiceP, where Voice introduces the Agent (overt/null) in Spec. When overt, Voice retains Case-assignment per Burzio's Generalization (1986), maintaining external argument projection.

(4) $[_{TP}\ Subj_{[\Phi][A']}\ T_{[\Phi]}\ [_{PassP}\ t_{[\Phi][A']}\ Pass_{[\Phi+A']}\ [_{vP}\ (Ag.)\ [_{VP}\ NP_{[\Phi][A']}\ ]]]]$

ii. A-movement i. A/A'-movement

➢ Pylkkänen (2008) distinguishes low vs. high Applicatives

◆ Low Appl: IO and DO are semantically linked (e.g., possession), with Appl merged low in VP.

(5a) $[_{VP}\ V\ [_{ApplP}\ IO\ [_{Appl'}\ Appl\ DO]]]$

◆ High Appl: No inherent semantic relation; Appl merges higher, outside VP, linking the applied object to V, i.e. the event itself.

(5b) $[_{ApplP}\ IO\ [_{Appl'}\ Appl\ [_{VP}\ V\ DO]]]$

Case Licence

Assuming a bottom-up derivation and *Earliness Principle* (Pesetsky 1989):——

➢ Canonical Ditransitive DOCs:

◆ Agent-overt: v → IO Pass → Agent T → DO

◆ Agentless: ~~v~~ Pass → IO T → DO

➢ Non-canonical DOCs (with ApplP):

◆ Agent-overt: Appl → DO v → IO Pass → Agent

◆ Agentless: Appl → DO ~~v~~ Pass → IO

⚠ All movement is feature-driven, so that a DP can move from one Case position to another. This ensures Case licence via c-command, preserving probe-goal locality.

Implications

While Mandarin permits flexible argument expression, this flexibility operates within a grammatically constrained system where lexical valency, syntactic phasehood, and semantic dependency jointly determine the well-formedness. The analysis thus contributes to broader theoretical debates on the syntax-semantics interface, offering a model for reconciling categorical rigidity with contextual adaptability in language design.

Selected Reference: Abels, Klaus. 2003. *Successive cyclicity, anti-locality, and adposition stranding*. University of Connecticut. Bruening, Benjamin. 2013. By phrases in passives and nominals. *Syntax*, 16(1), 1-41. Chen, Fulang. 2023. *Obscured universality in Mandarin*. PhD diss., MIT. Chomsky, Norm. 2001. Derivation by phase. In *Ken Hale: A Life in Language*, ed. by Michael Kenstowicz, 1-52, Cambridge, MA: MIT Press. Burzio, Luigi. 1986. *Italian syntax: A government-binding approach*. Vol. 1. Springer Science & Business Media. Kratzer, Angelika. 1996. Severing the external argument from its verb. *Phrase structure and the lexicon*, 109-137. Dordrecht: Springer Netherlands. Pylkkänen, Liina. 2008. *Introducing arguments.* Vol. 49. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.